

Cluniac

During the 250 years after its foundation in 910 CE, the monastic house of Cluny (pictured) grew to be the most important in Europe. Thousands of monasteries and churches were built in its Romanesque style, spreading from Germany to France and often sited along popular 12th-century pilgrimages.

Among the most important of these was St Sernin in Toulouse (c.1080–1120), the largest church along the route to Santiago de Compostela in Spain. Built in a soft orange brick, on a crucifix plan, St Sernin has a long, barrel-vaulted nave with transverse arches and a 65-metre (213-ft) octagonal bell tower. The basilica is 115 metres (377 ft) long and 21 metres (69 ft) high, creating a vast, calm interior space. Nine chapels leading off the transepts and apse enabled pilgrims to pay their respects to relics, which in previous eras were usually hidden away from view in crypts. The Cathedral of Santiago de Compostela itself mirrors St Sernin: built in 1075–1122, mostly from granite, it too has nine radiating chapels and a wide ambulatory (processional walkway).

